

A fully-local router?

There was a surprise ruling from the United States Federal Communications Commission (FCC) recently which put consumer-grade routers made in foreign countries on its 'Covered List'. The message is quite unmistakable: a home networking router is no longer being treated as a harmless piece of technology. It is now labelled as a piece of strategic infrastructure that happens to sit beside the television.

That raises an obvious question for India. Could New Delhi pull off something similar and insist that all consumer networking products sold in India ought to be manufactured domestically? In policy terms, yes.

For starters, India already has enacted some of the regulatory framework needed for such a localisation move. The Trusted Telecom Portal, created under the National Security Directive on Telecommunication Sector (NSDTS), already allows the government to designate trusted sources and trusted products for telecom networks. While this is meant for telecom networks, it can be the blueprint for extension to other sectors.

The Code of Practice for Securing Consumer Internet of Things (IoT), first released in 2021 and updated in 2025, sets out requirements such as no universal default passwords, secure software updates and vulnerability handling. The Mandatory Testing and Certification of Telecommunication Equipment (MTCTE) framework also gives the government a route to make compliance meaningful before products are imported into the country and sold.

India can already point to genuine domestic capability in networking equipment, especially on the operator and public-infrastructure side. Indian companies such as HFCL and ITI have supplied routing equipment for BharatNet. That proves India can build networking hardware. It does not yet prove that India can replace the entirety of the consumer router market, that too at scale, and without disruption.

That is because consumer networking is not just a hardware story. A good home



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Mithun Mohandas
Managing Editor



Let me know your thoughts on this column at:
@mithun_mohandas |
mithun@digit.in

router is an amalgamation of silicon, firmware, mobile software, cloud management, security patching, distribution, support, and price discipline. Manufacturing telecom hardware for operators is one thing. Building a polished, mass-market standalone or mesh Wi-Fi product that can compete on price and user experience is quite another.

The semiconductor picture is improving, but it is still a work in progress. The government said in February this year that 10 semiconductor projects had been approved across six states under the Semicon India programme. India is building capacity, but the ecosystem is not yet self-contained.

Even beyond silicon, India would need stronger control over the deeper supply chain. A router assembled in India is not automatically deemed 'sovereign' if the critical components remain dependent on external vendors only.

This is why a sudden “make every router in India” rule would be more theatre than strategy. It could narrow consumer choice, raise prices, and leave buyers relying more heavily on whatever hardware their internet service provider supplies.

So, can India do the same as the United States? Yes, if the question is about regulation. India could plausibly introduce a trusted-source regime for consumer networking products, tighten testing, and restrict certain categories of imports within the next 12-to-24 months, if it wanted.

The answer is 'no', if the question is whether India can do so cleanly and painlessly today. The domestic industry is not yet ready to replace the breadth, polish and scale of the global consumer-router market. A smarter way to go about this would be phased, not dramatic decisions that shock the system.

As for timing, India could enact a rule similar in spirit within two years. But to truly make such a rule work, five to seven years is the more realistic window.

That may sound slow, but electronics supply chains move on industrial timelines, not political ones. **d**